

A night of looking, listening, and learning

45 minutes in class + an optional supervised evening observation

What students will learn

Recognise several Quechua sky names; distinguish a star, planet, Moon, star cluster, and galaxy; connect an observation with a clearly attributed cultural account.

Prepare before the lesson

Bring this guide, pencils, a compass or map, warm clothing, and a dim red torch. Choose an accessible, permitted observing place with a clear horizon. Check the weather and arrange adult supervision. No telescope is required.

Safety first

Never look directly at the Sun, especially through binoculars or a telescope. Teach Inti through shadows or images. For this activity, use binoculars only after sunset and under adult supervision. Agree on boundaries and keep pupils together.

1 / In class - 10 minutes

Ask: Which sky names do you know in your own languages? Introduce Inti, Killa (also written Quilla), Collca/Qollqa, and Mayu. Explain that Quechua is a family of language varieties; spelling, stories, and names vary by place.

2 / Plan your sky - 15 minutes

Open Stellarium. Set your actual location with F6, then your observing date and local time with F5. Search with F3 for Moon, M45 (the Pleiades), and Alpha Centauri. Check whether each is above the horizon after dark. If not, choose another date or use the simulation. On some keyboards hold Fn with the function key.

3 / Observe or simulate - 20 minutes

Find the horizon and a compass direction first. Let eyes adjust to darkness for about 20-30 minutes; avoid bright screens. Begin with the Moon or Pleiades if visible. Draw what you really see. For a cloudy-day alternative, do the same activity in Stellarium.

Meet the sky names

A starting collection, not a complete dictionary of Quechua astronomy

Inti | Sun

A star and a central Inka sacred figure. Observe the changing position of a stick's shadow; never stare at the Sun. [1, 2]

Killa / Quilla | Moon

Mama Quilla is a name used in accounts of Inka religion. Compare the Moon's shape on different nights; a date-specific sky chart tells you when it is visible. [2]

Chasca | Venus

Garcilaso records the name Chasca for Venus. Venus is a planet, although it is often called a morning or evening star. Its visibility changes: confirm the date and direction in a planetarium before observing. [3]

Collca / Qollqa | Pleiades (M45)

A compact cluster of stars, important in Andean agricultural calendars. Search for M45 in Stellarium, then compare its tight grouping with the surrounding stars. It is not visible at every hour or season. [1, 2]

Llamaq ñawin | Alpha and Beta Centauri

The two bright stars are described as the llama's eyes in Andean sky traditions. They are southern-sky targets: they never rise at many northern latitudes. Use Cusco in a simulation if unavailable locally. Regional forms differ. [2, 4]

Mayu | Milky Way

The celestial river. Choose a moonless, dark night and look for a faint broad band. Dark patterns include the llama, Yutu (tinamou), Hanp'ata (toad), and Machacuay (snake) in the cited account. These are dark-cloud figures, not individual stars. Photographs show more contrast than eyes. [2]

Observation & listening sheet

Name: _____ Class: _____

Record the conditions

Place: _____ Date: _____ Local time: _____
Weather / clouds: _____ Direction faced: _____

What did you find?

Quechua name and spelling: _____
Astronomical name: _____
Observed outdoors or in a simulation? _____

Sketch the horizon and object. Add a compass direction.

Use dots for stars; show dark areas only if you could see them.

Listen respectfully

If someone shares a story, ask permission before writing or publishing it. Record how they wish to be credited, the community or region, the language variety, and whether the story is personal, oral, or from a publication. Do not present one account as the belief of every Quechua community.

Reflect together

What did you observe directly? What did you learn from someone else? How do stories and careful observations offer different ways of relating to the same sky? What would you like to ask a local knowledge holder?

Sources & teaching notes

Use the links to check the names and discuss where accounts come from

1. Smithsonian, National Museum of the American Indian

Reciprocity - Andean Style. Inti, the Pléiades/Colca, and living Andean festivals.

[Open source online](#)

2. GLORIA project (2014), Astronomy of the Incas

Pío Jiménez, Hanlon and Serra-Ricart. Pages 8-10: Inti, Quilla, Mayu, Collca, and the dark-cloud figures.

[Open source online](#)

3. Inca Garcilaso de la Vega, Comentarios reales

First part, Book III, chapter XXI. Colonial-era account naming Venus Chasca. Read historical accounts critically; they are not a universal modern dictionary.

[Open source online](#)

4. Anthropologica, PUCP: Andean sky-name discussion

The note on LLAMACÑAWIN explains Llamaq ñawin and Ayacucho variants, and identifies the stars as Alpha and Beta Centauri.

[Open source online](#)

5. NASA: Stargazing for Beginners (May 2024)

Practical advice on dark skies, night vision, and observing without expensive equipment.

[Open source online](#)

6. Stellarium User Guide

Instructions for setting location, date/time, and searching for objects.

[Open source online](#)

About this guide

Prepared for Mayu, September 2026. English explanations with selected Quechua names. Cultural sources, modern teaching advice, and community contributions should remain distinguishable. Invite review by a local Quechua speaker or educator before treating spelling as a local standard.